

Historical Matrix: Spain and the New World (1492–1600)

English 11 — Unit 2: Divergent Viewpoints & Narrative Friction | Primary Reference Resource

Institutional Driver	15th-Century Historical Context	Primary Objective	Rhetorical Impact on Primary Sources
Crown & Monarchy	Ferdinand & Isabella post-Reconquista (1492); consolidating power and funding rival naval empires.	Assert territorial sovereignty, extract royal fifth (Quinto Real), expand Spanish empire.	Framing claims using legally binding, grandiose declarations of ownership; emphasizing order and royal authority.
Mercantilism & Commerce	Search for direct sea routes to Asian spice markets; high national debt from European warfare.	Locate gold, silver, spices, fertile agricultural land, and trade commodities.	Hyperbolic, inventory-like catalogs of landscape resources ('Edenic diction'); minimizing perceived risks.
Catholic Church & Papal Mandate	Papal Bulls (e.g., <i>Inter Caetera</i> , 1493) granting Spain exclusive rights to newly discovered lands.	Evangelize and convert indigenous populations to Catholicism; legitimize imperial expansion.	Describing indigenous people as morally innocent, 'gentle,' and ripe for conversion to frame conquest as a holy mission.
Socio-Cultural Norms	Feudal chivalric ethos, nobility status tied to land ownership, strict social hierarchies.	Gain personal titles (e.g., 'Admiral of the Ocean Sea'), land grants, and encomienda labor.	Ethnocentric framing; evaluating non-European societies by European standards of dress, technology, and governance.

Analytical Guiding Questions for Close Reading

- **Audience Alignment:** Which matrix categories above most directly explain why Christopher Columbus focused heavily on gold and fertile soil in his 1493 letter?
- **Textual Omissions:** How does the Papal Mandate encourage chroniclers to omit or downplay Spanish military violence in official reports?
- **Synthesis:** Select one paragraph from Columbus's *Letter of Discovery* and map its specific word choices to one or more drivers from this matrix.